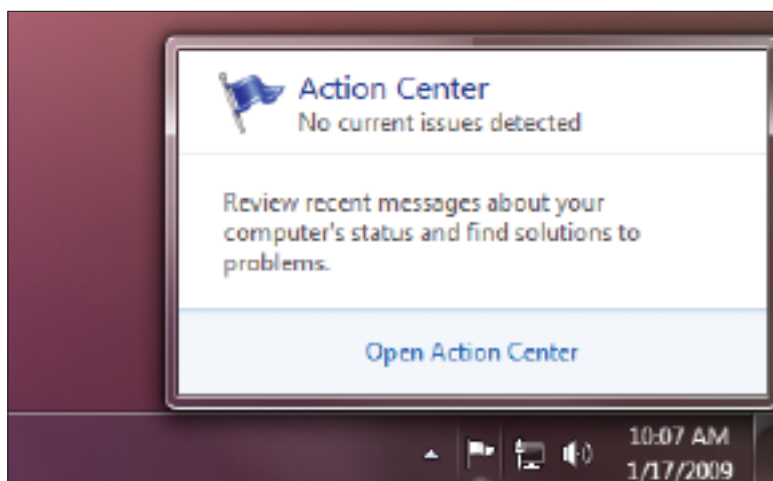




Action Center

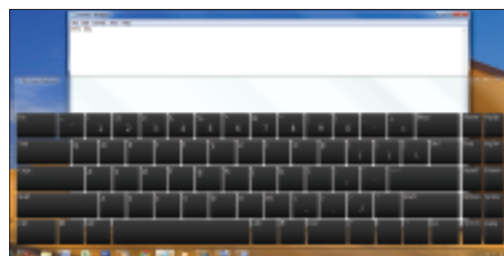
solutions to system and/or program crashes. The Action Center is also where the System Restore feature resides. Finally, we have the Troubleshooting option, which is a surprisingly useful (in that it actually solves issues, no really, it does!) list of tasks and wizards to handle everything from running a program made for previous versions of Windows to power management. It helped us run quite a few irate programs...

Miscellany

1. Themes: Right-click on your desktop, select Personalize and you will be able to change sundry items that give your setup its identity — colour, sounds, and the screensaver. Moreover, you can select multiple images to be used as your desktop wallpaper and tell Windows to cycle through them after a specific interval. Watching your desktop change wallpapers (especially if they are cool abstracts) every 30 seconds is very cool indeed. You can also save your settings as a theme. Very nice.
2. Gadgets: We would love to tell you more about these, but no matter how hard we tried, we could not get them to work. The change in this Beta is that you now drop



Create and save a theme



On Screen Keyboard

Get yer shortcut keys here

New shortcuts to navigating Windows 7

Win+Home	Minimize all but the active window
Win+Space	See through to the desktop
Win+Up arrow	Maximize the active window
Win+Down arrow	Minimize/restore the active window
Win+Left/Right arrows	Dock the window to each side of the monitor
Win+Shift+Left+Right arrow	Move the window to the adjacent monitor (for dual-monitor setups).
Win+T	Focus and scroll through items on the taskbar
Win+P	Adjust presentation settings for your display
Win+(+/-)	Zoom in/out
Shift+Click a taskbar item	Open a new instance of that application

gadgets to your desktop. The irritating sidebar is gone. But every time we dropped one, it would simply disappear.

3. On-Screen keyboard. This is finally using vector images and is thus scalable. Moreover, it now offers text prediction and text completion — making it a great feature for those with weak eyes or for those too lazy to walk to their physical keyboard.

Closing thoughts

Windows 7 Beta does all the right things. It fixes what was broken, introduces some great and useful features, runs faster, feels snappier, and is reportedly less demanding on hardware. It's everything that Windows Vista should have been. We would go as far as saying that this Beta should have been a service pack to Windows Vista (and maybe some features will indeed make it to SP2). While

this Beta generally cleans up after Vista, we would personally like to see more innovations as we head towards the retail release.

Through Windows 7, Microsoft has thought it wiser to clean the slate and release anew, rather than try and salvage Vista's tarnished reputation. That doesn't change the fact that Windows Vista users might feel cheated. But isn't that the nature of technology? Early adopters beware. If nothing else, Windows 7 seems on track to fulfilling promises made during the Longhorn era.

For that alone, we are excited to see more of Windows 7. What can we say? Some people never learn... ■

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